

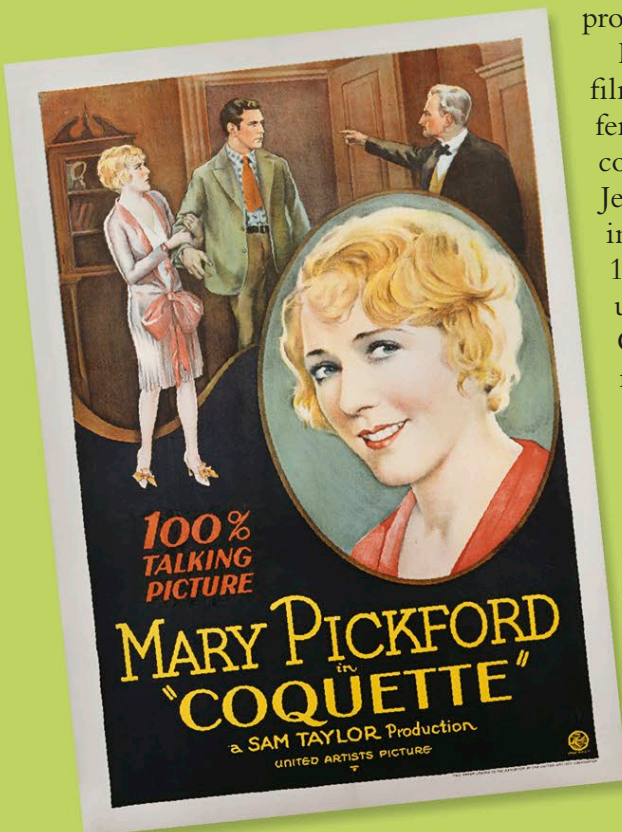
THROUGH THE AGES

Cinema

Women played major roles in cinema's Golden Age of the 1920s and 1930s, but lost their footing in Hollywood as it became more corporate and male-dominated. In recent decades women have attempted to bridge the gap of inequality and tell more female-driven stories.

▼ Girl with the curls

Mary Pickford won the second ever Academy Award for best actress for her portrayal of a girl whose reputation is ruined, in *Coquette* (1929). It was Pickford's first ever talking role.



IN MORE THAN A CENTURY of cinema, depictions of women on the silver screen have often reflected the dreams and desires of the male audience. According to pioneering American director D. W. Griffith, audiences in the early 1900s did not want gritty depictions of reality: they wanted “a gun and a girl.” Despite this idea, in the 1910s and '20s, women wielded more influence than at any other time. One of Griffith's “girls” was Canadian-born Mary Pickford, who became one of the first true Hollywood stars. After founding her own

company in 1916, Pickford produced all of her own films.

In the early 1930s, many films featured self-determined female characters who defied conventional morality, such as Jean Harlow's home-wrecker in *Red-Headed Woman*. From 1934, however, censorship under the puritanical Hays Code forced Hollywood to make less controversial entertainment, with even married couples sleeping in twin beds. Only wholesome heroines triumphed, and women with a past were punished. During the 1950s and '60s, leading actresses such as Doris Day, Debbie Reynolds, Audrey Hepburn, and Grace Kelly achieved success playing good girls.

“An **actress** is **not** a **machine**, but they **treat you** like a **machine**.”

MARILYN MONROE

The shift to a male-dominated Hollywood was reflected behind the scenes too, with the advent of the studio system, starting in 1924 with Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer (MGM). Before 1920, there were more than 30 women directors, but the increasingly corporate nature of Hollywood put men in charge. Among the few exceptions was Dorothy Arzner, who was the only female director working in the 1930s and '40s, until 1949, when actress Ida Lupino began to direct. Lupino was then the only woman to direct a major feature film until Elaine May in 1971.

Bigger roles

One of Hollywood's first female film editors, Verna Fields, won an Oscar for *Jaws* (1975), and around that time, the growing Women's Liberation Movement (see pp. 272–275) helped to bring more interesting female characters to the screen. Breakthroughs came in 1979 with director Gillian Armstrong's *My Brilliant Career*, about an ambitious writer played by